

incompatible differences became formalized into the Seelie and Unseelie Courts.

They held nothing but hatred and contempt for one another. The Seelie Court accused the Unseelie of lawlessness and treachery while the Unseelie Court charged that the Seelie were despotic tyrants. Neither court had enough power to gain advantage over the other, so stalemate reigned. Unimaginably powerful oaths were crafted to end the impasse and force the two sides to share power. For countless centuries, the courts existed in a state of balance. The Seelie Court was given rulership over the spring and summer months, beginning with Beltane. From Samhain on, the Unseelie Court held dominion over the autumn and winter months. This exchange ensured the turning of the seasons and infused the world with aspects of both courts in equal measure. The Seelie Court brought germination, warmth, and new growth. The Unseelie Court provided harvest, frost, and decay. Through their combined efforts, humanity thrived, providing both courts with ample Glamour.

Banality's first toehold in the world brought with it the Sundering. The fae could feel their power weakening as Glamour began to wane. The two courts fundamentally disagreed on how to address the problem. The Seelie Court felt the solution was to continue what worked for ages. They thought the fae simply lost their focus and needed to redouble their efforts. The Unseelie Court believed the Kithain needed to confront Banality head on, and fight it wherever it may lie. The annual exchange of power prevented either court from fully enacting its solution. Glamour continued growing more scarce, with neither court able to act to staunch its withdrawal. Eventually the situation grew to be intolerable, and the High King refused to step down. The identity of the court that actually broke the oath is lost to the mists of time. Whichever it was, instead of stepping down, he ordered his court's plan into action. Whether on the order of their High King or as an act of rebellion against a Seelie Court that overstepped its bounds, no one knows — but the Unseelie Court declared war on all Banality.

WAR OF THE COURTS

The Unseelie were relentless in their purge. They destroyed entire villages to eliminate a single Autumn Person. It was justified, they claimed. Banality was like a gangrenous limb. The only way to stop its spread was to cut it off. Instead of ripping out Banality at its roots, the only thing the Unseelie Court accomplished was wantonly murdering Dreamers and driving the survivors to hopeless despair. To stop the mindless destruction of Glamour, the Seelie Court declared war on the Unseelie.

Chaos reigned. The ensuing war was unlike any seen on Earth since the War of Trees. Great beasts — terrible wyrms and horrors slumbering just beneath the skin of the world, dormant since the time of legends — were summoned. Battles raged across the entirety of the Kithain's known world. As weakened as the fae of the Sundering perceived themselves, they wielded the power of gods when compared to changelings of today. As the conflict raged, the cycle of life grew ever more out of balance. Winter lasted nearly whole years, and floods drowned crops in their fields. The twin terrors of famine and freezing left nothing

WAR OF SEASONS

Dismissed as conspiracy theorists by most of changeling society, a handful of historians claim to have uncovered a shocking revelation — the Seelie and Unseelie Courts are not the ancient institutions the Kithain believe them to be. Through a combination of piecing together fragmented sources and new translations, they concluded that four courts predate the Seelie and Unseelie Courts: Spring, Summer, Autumn, and Winter.

These scholars say there was never any sharing of power between the original four courts. Instead, tensions only grew until a massive War of Seasons broke out. Casualties in this war were so heavy, there weren't enough Kithain left to support four courts by the time fighting ceased. The survivors consolidated themselves into the Seelie and Unseelie Courts. According to proponents of the four courts theory, the founders of the two courts spread propaganda that they shared power in antiquity as an attempt to ensure nothing like the War of Seasons ever happens again.

ing but death and suffering in their wake. Today, those early years of the 14th century are known to mortals as the Little Ice Age. The Kithain's story might have ended with their own eradication in the War of the Courts, but the Shattering put a premature end to their fighting.

TRUCE

As the Shattering severed the connections between Earth and the Dreaming, the courts' leadership fled to Arcadia, desperate to escape the rising tide of Banality. Each court blamed the other for the Shattering, and the War of the Courts continued even without their former leaders. With Glamour dying all around them, however, it was only a matter of time before the remaining fae had neither the strength nor the resources to continue their war. They signed a temporary cessation of hostilities, known as the Compact, and the two courts pooled their dwindling resources in the interest of mutual survival. Only by working together did the fae discover a method to adapt the old practice of the Changeling Way in a manner to survive the toxic environment of Banality during the Interregnum. Despite being designed to last only "for the duration," the Compact remained in effect for centuries.

The Resurgence brought Glamour and the nobility back to Earth. It also threatened to bring a return to the War of the Courts. The sidhe of both courts were all too happy to pick up the old animosities and accusations right where they left off. The commoners, however, grew accustomed to working together in the intervening centuries. Many changelings left behind during the Interregnum even counted members of the opposite court among their closest friends. When the sidhe